

Walter Gropius

Gropius (1883–1969), a pivotal figure in modernism, exerted an influence matched by few of his peers in Germany – where he founded the Bauhaus – or in the United States, where he moved after the Nazis seized power. After travelling Europe to study its architecture, he worked from 1907 to 1910 for Behrens. Then in 1911–13, with Adolf Meyer, he designed the Fagus shoe last factory in Alfeld, Germany (opposite), inspired by Behrens's AEG factory. Its glazed corners, hung daringly on a steel frame, convey a sense of lightness that contrasts with the solid brick entrance. His 1913 article 'The Development of Industrial Buildings' was influential, particularly on Mendelsohn and Le Corbusier. From 1919, Gropius served as master of the Weimar arts and crafts schools and turned them into the Bauhaus, employing some of the greatest artists and designers as teachers. His Bauhaus school complex at Dessau (1925) became a landmark in functionalism. Based in Massachusetts from the 1930s, he designed a series of striking homes that helped introduce modernism to America.

